

Tathya: PM Case Study

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Tathya is a facts-only chatbot for 5 HDFC mutual funds that cites a source and date on every answer, and refuses advice, returns and personal data. The product bet: in finance, a bot that says less but is always right and traceable earns more trust than one that answers everything.

Live

[Open the live app](#) ·
Code on [GitHub](#)

128 / 128

Quality: 128 test questions, including 31 adversarial ones, all passing

4 layers

Safety: keyword rules, AI intent check, answer check, number check

Free tier

Cost: runs on free tiers (Render, Groq) within 512 MB of memory

Context and why now

More investors in India now research mutual funds on apps on their own, without an adviser. At the same time, AI chatbots have become the default way people ask questions, but they are not built for finance: they guess numbers, rarely show a source, and drift into advice.

That leaves a gap: a fast, conversational way to check fund facts that is as trustworthy as reading the fund page yourself.

- **User shift:** self-directed investors want a quick answer, not a long fund page
- **Tech shift:** retrieval (RAG) plus fast, low-cost models make a sourced Q&A tool possible on free infrastructure
- **Trust gap:** in finance, a confident wrong answer or a hint of advice costs more than no answer

Problem

Retail investors ask simple factual questions (expense ratio, exit load, minimum SIP, lock-in) but get answers buried in long fund pages or mixed with opinions.

Generic AI chatbots make this worse in three ways:

- **Made-up or outdated numbers**, with no way to check where they came from
- **Advice slipping in** ("yes, it's a good fund"), which a facts tool must never give
- **Dropped conditions:** a fee rule shortened until it is wrong (for example, an exit load that applies only to units above 15% of the investment)

In finance, one wrong number or one hint of advice breaks trust, so accuracy and restraint matter more than coverage.

Users and jobs to be done

The primary user is a retail investor comparing or checking an HDFC fund before acting on a platform like Groww.

User	Job to be done	What they need from Tathya
First-time investor	"Tell me the basics of this fund in plain words."	Short answers, definitions, no jargon
Existing investor	"What will it cost me to exit or switch?"	Exact exit load and conditions, with the source
Tax saver (ELSS)	"How long is my money locked in?"	The lock-in period, stated precisely
Comparer	"Which of these has the lowest expense ratio?"	Factual comparison across funds, no opinion

Open question: these personas come from the brief, testing and one conversation with a senior banker, not from structured user interviews.

Alternatives and competitive landscape

Users can already find these facts; Tathya wins only if it is faster than the fund page and more trustworthy than a general chatbot.

Alternative	Strength	Weakness for this job	Tathya's edge
Fund page on Groww or the AMC site	Complete, detailed	Long page, facts scattered, no Q&A	A direct 1-3 sentence answer, citing the same page
AMC factsheets and scheme documents	Most authoritative	Dense PDFs, hard to search on a phone	Plain-language answers (official documents are a next step)
General AI chatbots	Conversational, any topic	No source, possible made-up numbers, may give advice	Cited, dated, facts-only, refuses advice
Distributor or customer support	Personal help	Slow, can mix facts with selling	Instant, neutral, no sales pressure

Positioning: the fund page, answered: the speed of a chatbot with the trust of the source.

Goals, non-goals and success metrics

The goal was a trustworthy facts tool, so the metrics measure correctness and safety, not engagement.

Goals

- ✓ Answer factual questions about 5 HDFC funds correctly, in 1-3 sentences
- ✓ Cite one source and its date on every factual answer
- ✓ Never give investment advice, returns or predictions
- ✓ Work on mobile, tablet and desktop

Non-goals

- ✗ Recommendations, portfolio advice or tax planning
- ✗ Live NAV, returns or performance data
- ✗ Other AMCs or other HDFC schemes
- ✗ Logins or saved history

Success metrics

Metric	Target	Result
Eval questions passing	100%	128 / 128
Adversarial questions refused or handled correctly	100%	31 / 31
Factual answers with source + date	100%	Attached by code, not the model
Runs on free hosting	Within 512 MB RAM	Peak about 250 MB in testing

Metrics framework for launch

The table above measures build quality. For a real launch, success means users get trusted answers, so the metrics move to user outcomes. These are proposed targets, not yet measured.

North star: trusted answers per week: factual answers shown with a source that are not followed by a rephrase or a thumbs-down.

Type	Metric	Why it matters	Proposed target
Input	Answer rate on in-scope questions	Coverage of what users really ask	80% or more
Input	Follow-up rate (2+ questions in a session)	The chat is useful, not one-off	30% or more
Input	Source-link click-through	Users verify, a trust signal	Track first
Input	Funds page to "Ask about this fund"	Browsing turns into questions	Track first

Type	Metric	Why it matters	Proposed target
Guardrail	Advice leakage (advice language in any reply)	Regulatory and trust risk	0
Guardrail	Wrong-fact reports	Accuracy is the core promise	Under 1% of answers
Guardrail	False refusals (valid question refused)	Over-caution hurts usefulness	Under 5%
Guardrail	Response time, warm (95th percentile)	Speed is the edge over the fund page	Under 4 seconds

Prioritisation: what to build first

With one builder and free infrastructure, scope came down to one question: does this make answers more trustworthy, or just more? Each candidate was scored on user value, trust impact and effort, then sorted with MoSCoW (must, should, later, won't).

Feature	User value	Trust impact	Effort	Decision
Source and date on every answer	High	High	Low	Must (v1)
Advice, returns and personal-data refusals	High	High	Medium	Must (v1)
Follow-ups that remember the fund	High	Medium	Medium	Should (v1)
Source facts panel and Funds page	Medium	High	Medium	Should (v1)
Responsive mobile UI	High	Low	Medium	Should (v1)
More funds and AMCs	High	Low	High	Later, after freshness checks
Live NAV and returns	High	Negative (close to advice)	High	Won't (non-goal)
Login and saved history	Low	Low	High	Won't

Rule used: anything that could make an answer wrong or advice-like was cut, even when users would want it.

Solution overview

Tathya answers from a curated set of 5 Groww fund pages, and every question passes safety checks before and after the AI writes an answer.

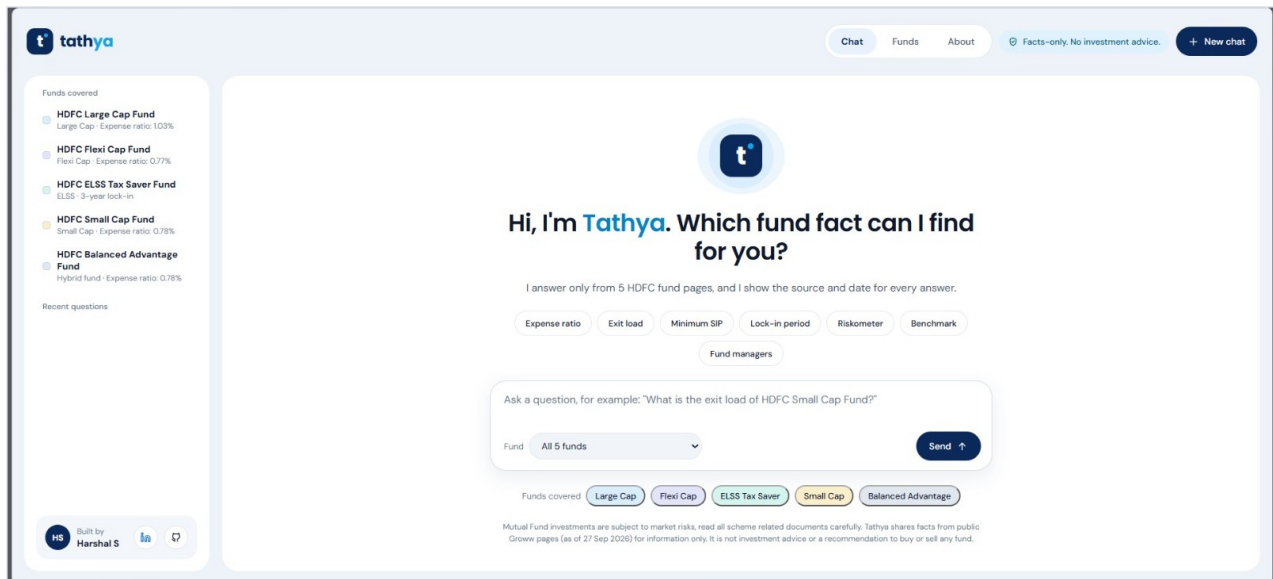


Figure 1 • Desktop home: topic chips, a fund selector and the facts-only promise up front

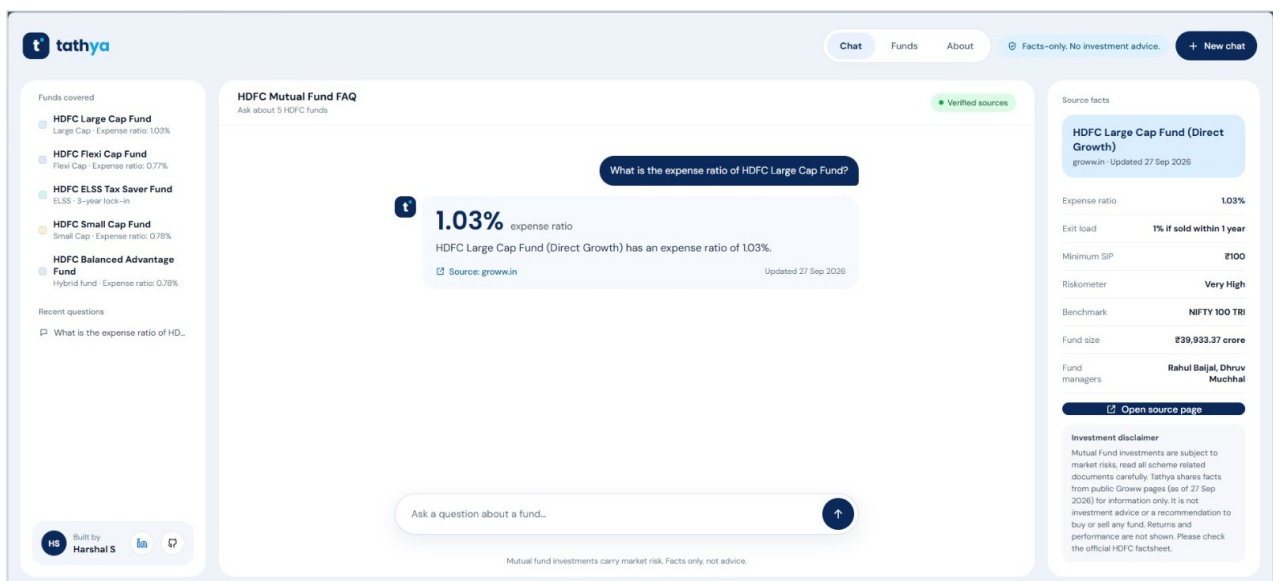
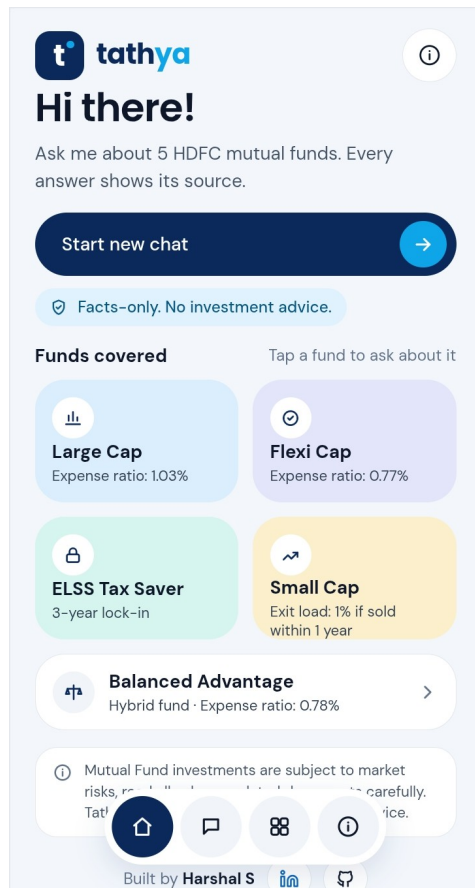


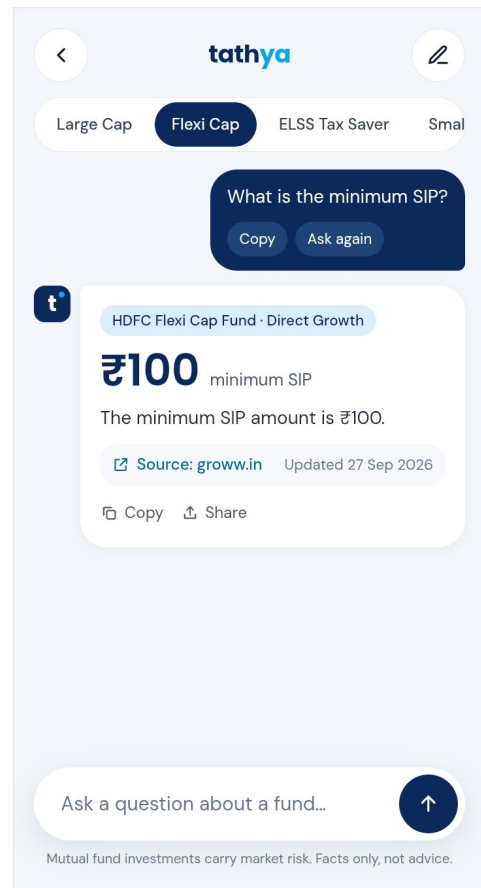
Figure 2 • Desktop answer: the key number shown large, the source and date, and the Source facts panel on the right

What users get

- A chat that shows the key number big (for example, 1.03%), the sentence, and "Source: groww.in · Updated 27 Sep 2026"
- Follow-ups that remember the fund ("What is the exit load?" after asking about Flexi Cap)
- A Source facts panel, a Funds page with key facts for all 5 funds, and an About page
- Clear refusal cards for advice, returns and personal data

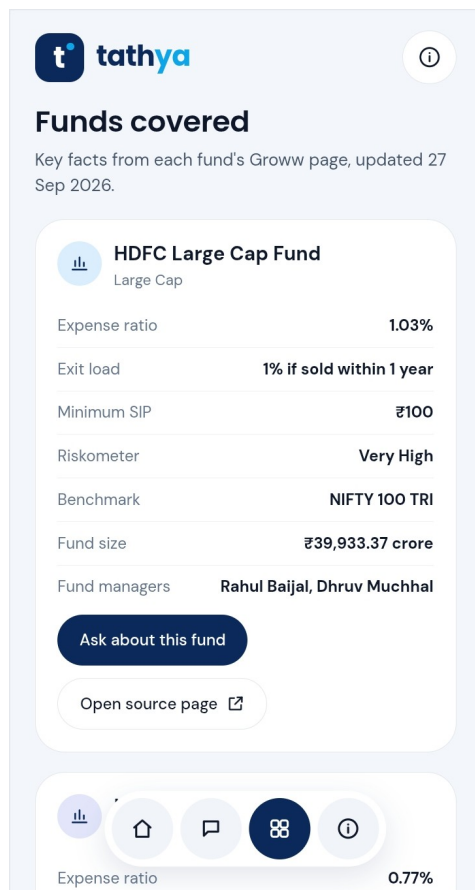


Home

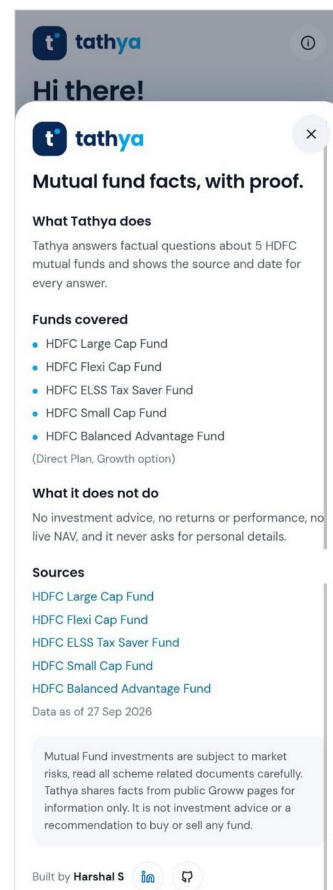


Chat

Figure 3 • Mobile home and chat: fund tiles with a bottom nav; after tapping Flexi Cap, "What is the minimum SIP?" is answered for that fund



Funds page



About sheet

Figure 4 • Funds page with key facts for all 5 funds, and the About sheet that states what Tathya does not do

How a question is handled

1. Personal data check (PAN, Aadhaar, phone, email): refuse and store nothing
2. Greeting, identity or thanks: short friendly reply
3. Keyword rules: advice, returns, live NAV, plan type, other funds, missing fund name
4. AI intent check, only for ambiguous questions
5. Search the fund's facts (vector search, minimum match score 0.55)
6. The AI writes a 1–3 sentence answer from the matched fact only
7. Answer check: block any advice language
8. Number check: every number must appear in the source text
9. Code attaches the source link and date

Stack: FastAPI, ChromaDB, all-MiniLM-L6-v2 embeddings (ONNX), Groq openai/gpt-oss-20b, vanilla HTML/CSS/JS, Docker on Render.

Key product decisions and trade-offs

Most decisions traded coverage or speed for trust, because trust is the product.

Decision	Why	Trade-off accepted
5 funds, Direct Growth only	Small scope I could verify fact by fact	Users with other funds are turned away
One fact per chunk (split by heading)	Precise matches and exact citations	More manual curation of the corpus
Code attaches the source and date, not the AI	The AI cannot invent a citation	Less flexible answer formatting
Minimum match score 0.55	Weak matches say "I don't have that information yet" instead of guessing	Some valid but vaguely worded questions are not answered
Refuse anything advice-like, even "can I buy it?"	A facts tool must never sound like a recommendation	Some harmless how-to questions need careful exceptions
AI intent check only for ambiguous questions	Clear fact questions skip an extra AI call, staying within Groq's free limits	Detection of vague advice depends on one extra model call
Free hosting (Render, Groq free tier)	Zero running cost for a portfolio project	First load after idle takes about a minute; rate limits
Friendly refusal wording with a title	A refusal should still help (link to AMFI or the factsheet)	More copy to maintain and test

Safety by design: four layers

No single rule catches every way people ask for advice, so Tathya stacks four checks, like a guard at the gate plus a check at the exit.

Every question passes checks before and after the AI writes

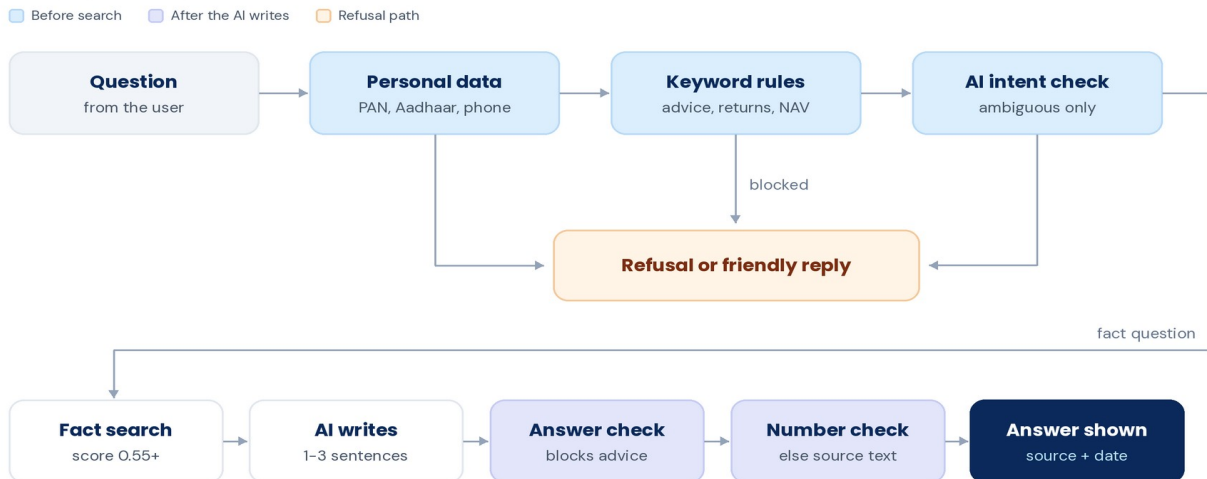


Figure 5 • Safety flow: 2 checks before search, 2 after the AI writes

Blocked questions get a refusal card; an answer whose numbers are not in the source falls back to the exact source sentence.

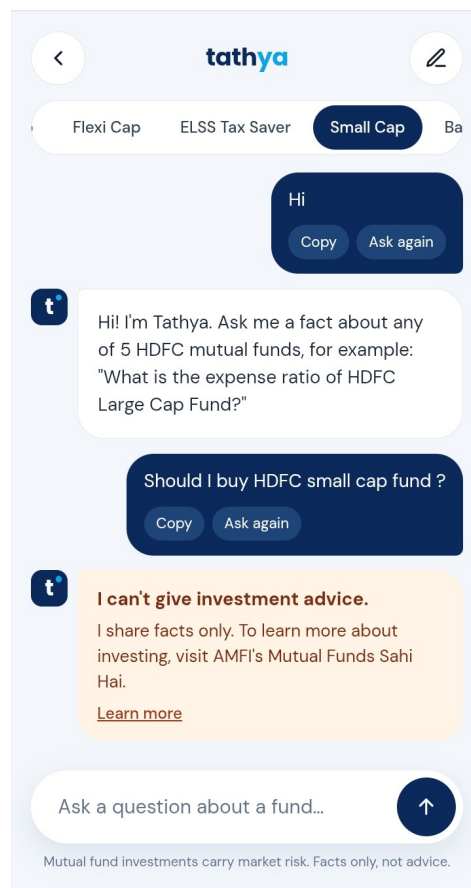


Figure 6 • Refusal card: advice is declined in a warm card with a clear title and a Learn more link, while a greeting gets a friendly info card

Layer	When it runs	What it catches	Example
1. Keyword rules	Before search	Obvious advice, returns, personal data, live NAV, other funds	"Should I buy HDFC Small Cap Fund?"

Layer	When it runs	What it catches	Example
2. AI intent check	Before search, only for ambiguous questions	Indirect, Hinglish and role-play advice; nonsense	"kharidu kya?", "will it go up?", "pretend you are an advisor"
3. Answer check	After the AI writes	Advice language that slipped through	Answer containing "you should" or "good choice" is replaced
4. Number check	After the AI writes	Numbers not found in the source	A made-up figure falls back to the exact source sentence

The AI is also instructed to keep every condition from the source, so the Balanced Advantage exit load always mentions "units above 15% of the investment".

Evaluation

Every change was checked against an eval set that grew from 53 to 128 questions as testing found new failure types.

- **What each test checks:** the reply type (answer, advice refusal, returns refusal, personal data, out of scope, clarify, greeting, not found), text it must contain, and text it must not contain (for example, an advice refusal must never include "you should" or "yes, you can")
- **Follow-ups:** tests can send a selected fund, so "What is the exit load?" is checked for each of the 5 funds
- **Adversarial set (31 questions):** indirect advice, Hinglish, predictions, role-play and jailbreak attempts, mixed fact + advice, personal data, gibberish and look-alike funds
- **Speed:** a 32-question quick run for small changes, a full run before each release, and a "re-run failures" mode
- **Rule:** never lower a threshold or delete a test to make it pass; fix the cause instead

Iteration log: real bugs found in testing

Hands-on testing, especially on the live site, found issues the automated tests had missed; each fix also added tests so the bug cannot return.

What a user saw	Root cause	Fix
Wrong fund managers shown as chips (Large Cap managers on a Flexi Cap answer)	Chips came from the wrong fund's data	Chips built from the answer's own fund, only for manager questions
Balanced Advantage exit load missing "units above 15%"	The AI shortened the fact	Rule to keep every condition, plus a test that requires "15%"
"Shall I buy it?" answered with the fund objective	Advice phrasing not recognised	More advice patterns plus the AI intent check

What a user saw	Root cause	Fix
"abcd" answered with a random fund fact	The active fund name was added to every search	Add the fund name only to real fact follow-ups
Follow-up "What is the exit load?" got "Which fund?"	The page sent a fund name the search filter could not match	One source of truth for fund names, from the funds data
Weaker matches being accepted	Match threshold had drifted from 0.55 to 0.40	Restored 0.55 in one shared setting
Advice and "hello" replies never appeared	The page expected every reply to have a fund and source	Separate card styles for refusals and info replies
Live site crashed on startup	Over 512 MB memory on the free plan	Load the model once and build the index at build time

Results

Tathya is live, passes all 128 eval questions, and refuses every advice, returns and personal-data question in the adversarial set.

- **Correctness:** factual answers match the verified source values for all 5 funds, including conditional facts like the 15% exit-load rule
- **Safety:** 31 of 31 adversarial questions handled correctly, with no advice language in any refusal
- **Experience:** one responsive app for mobile, tablet and desktop; follow-ups remember the fund; every answer shows its source and date
- **Cost:** runs entirely on free tiers, with no rate-limit errors in the final full eval run

Not yet measured: real-user usage, satisfaction or retention, since the product has not had a public launch.

Risks and assumptions

Risk or assumption	Impact	Mitigation
Data goes stale (fees or managers change)	Old facts shown as current	"Updated <date>" on every answer; planned scheduled re-fetch with a diff check
Groww pages are not the official source	Credibility gap	Clear disclaimer; move to AMC factsheets next
Replies read as investment advice	Regulatory and trust risk	Four safety layers, refusal wording and a disclaimer on every screen

Risk or assumption	Impact	Mitigation
Over-refusal	Useful questions blocked, users leave	Track false refusals; exceptions for how-to questions ("How do I invest via SIP?")
AI model behaviour changes	Silent drop in quality	128-question eval before every release
Free-tier limits and cold starts	Slow or failed answers at peak	Skip the AI check for clear questions; extractive fallback; paid tier if usage grows
Assumption: users want facts, not opinions	Product may feel too strict	Validate in launch phase 1 with real users

Launch and experiment plan

Launch in small steps, learn what people really ask, and widen scope only while the guardrails hold.

Phase	Who	Goal	Move on when
1. Friends and family	20–30 investors	Real questions and first feedback	Answer rate 80%+, zero advice leaks
2. Public beta	LinkedIn and investor communities	Usage patterns and trust signals	False refusals under 5%, wrong-fact reports under 1%
3. Scale	Wider audience, more funds	Coverage	Freshness checks live, eval extended for each new batch

First experiments

- **Big-number card vs plain sentence:** does showing "1.03%" large help users find the answer faster?
- **Refusal with a helpful link vs plain refusal:** do more users click AMFI or the factsheet, and fewer rephrase the same advice question?
- **Topic chips vs an empty box:** do suggested chips raise the answer rate for first-time users?

What I would do next

The next step is real-user learning, then scale the data safely.

1. **Measure with real users:** log anonymised question types, refusal rate, "I don't have that" rate and source-link clicks, to see what people actually ask
2. **Fresh data:** a scheduled re-fetch of source pages with a diff check, so changed fees or managers are flagged before they go live
3. **Official sources:** move from Groww pages to AMC factsheets and scheme documents, keeping one citation per answer

4. **More funds:** add funds in batches, each batch with its own eval rows before release
5. **Feedback:** a thumbs up/down on answers to find wrong or unhelpful replies quickly
6. **Reliability:** a paid AI tier or a smaller model for the intent check if usage grows past free limits

Learnings

The biggest lesson: in a trust product, the work is mostly in what the bot must not say.

- **Passing tests is not the same as working.** Live testing found bugs (wrong managers, a dropped 15% condition) that 64 passing tests had missed; each became a new test.
- **Guard settings drift.** A key threshold quietly moved from 0.55 to 0.40; keeping it in one shared place stopped that.
- **Layers beat lists.** No keyword list covers every phrasing of advice; a cheap AI check for vague questions, plus checks on the answer itself, closed the gaps.
- **Small scope, done fully.** Five funds with verified facts beat many funds with doubtful ones.
- **Working with AI coding tools:** small, phased prompts with clear rules, plus checking every report (not trusting "should pass"), made the difference.

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